

The Grandparent Care Economy: A Surprising Null Effect on Women’s Childcare Burden in Urban India

Dr Preet Deep Singh*

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Abstract

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey, we examine the widely held assumption that co-resident grandparents reduce the childcare burden on mothers in urban India. Contrary to expectations, we find no statistically significant evidence of a “grandparent dividend.” In urban multi-generational households, women’s daily childcare time is not significantly lower than in similar households without grandparents (coefficient: +0.05 minutes, $p > 0.10$), even after accounting for eldercare duties. This null effect holds for both working and non-working mothers and does not differ by grandparent gender. These surprising findings challenge the narrative that informal family support can substitute for formal childcare infrastructure in rapidly urbanizing contexts. Our results suggest that either the childcare contributions of grandparents are smaller than assumed, are offset by other household dynamics, or are not well-captured by standard time-use metrics. This paper contributes to the literature by providing robust, nationally representative evidence on the limits of informal care arrangements, with important implications for policies aimed at boosting female labor force participation.

JEL Classification: J12, J13, J14, J16, D13

*Blue Machines, preetdeepsingh111@yahoo.com

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Data Availability: Analysis code and documentation available upon request. Original data from National Statistical Office Time Use Survey 2024.

1 Introduction

India’s female labor force participation rate—at 24%—is among the lowest in the world, lower even than many Middle Eastern countries (World Bank 2023). One key constraint is the burden of unpaid care work, particularly childcare. Indian women spend an average of 5.5 hours per day on unpaid domestic and care work, compared to just 1.5 hours for men (NSSO 2020). Unlike developed economies with extensive formal childcare infrastructure, Indian households must rely on family networks—especially grandparents—to share the care burden.

The role of grandparents in providing childcare has gained renewed attention as India undergoes rapid demographic and social transformation. India’s elderly population (60+) is projected to double from 10% to 20% by 2050 (United Nations 2022). Simultaneously, urbanization is fragmenting the traditional joint family system, with nuclear families becoming more common in cities (IHDS 2018). Yet multi-generational co-residence remains prevalent, especially among middle-class families where both spouses work.

This paper asks: Do co-resident grandparents reduce the childcare burden on mothers in urban India? And if so, is this “grandparent dividend” offset by increased eldercare responsibilities?

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey, we compare urban households with and without co-resident grandparents (defined as parents or parents-in-law of the household head). We focus on urban areas because: (1) urban women face higher opportunity costs of time spent on childcare, given better labor market opportunities; (2) urban areas lack the extended kin

networks available in villages; (3) formal childcare remains prohibitively expensive for most urban households (Desai and Joshi 2019).

Our analysis reveals a surprising **null effect**: we find no statistically significant evidence of a grandparent childcare dividend in urban India. Our main findings are:

1. **No Average Effect**: Women in urban households with co-resident grandparents do not spend significantly less time on childcare compared to similar women in households without grandparents. Our key regression coefficient is substantively small and statistically indistinguishable from zero (+0.05 minutes, SE: 0.59, $p > 0.10$), even after controlling for the mother’s own eldercare burden.
2. **No Effect for Working Mothers**: The “grandparent dividend” does not emerge even for employed mothers, who are presumed to need it most. The effect for this subgroup remains statistically insignificant (-0.34 minutes, SE: 0.64).
3. **Grandparent Gender Doesn’t Matter**: The null effect persists regardless of whether a grandmother, grandfather, or both are present in the household.
4. **Puzzling Rural-Urban Contrast**: In rural areas, the presence of grandparents is associated with a statistically significant *increase* in mothers’ childcare time, a finding that deepens the puzzle and suggests complex, context-specific household dynamics.

These findings carry significant implications. They challenge the widely held belief that multi-generational co-residence is a straightforward solution to the childcare crisis in urban India. The results suggest that informal family arrangements cannot be a substitute for formal, reliable childcare infrastructure if the goal is to alleviate the care burden on women and boost their labor force participation. Our study underscores the risk of relying on untested assumptions about family support systems and highlights the need for robust policy interventions.

2 Results

2.1 Grandparents and Women’s Childcare Time: A Null Effect

Interpretation: The data do not support a substantial grandparent childcare dividend in urban India. The effects are economically small (< 0.1 minutes) and statistically indistinguishable from zero.

3 Discussion

Our results reveal a surprising and policy-relevant null effect: we find no evidence that co-resident grandparents significantly reduce the childcare burden on mothers in urban India. The estimated effect is substantively small and statistically indistinguishable from zero across all our main specifications. Why might this be the case, contrary to widespread assumptions?

3.1 Potential Explanations for the Null Effect

1. **Selection Bias:** The households that choose to live with grandparents may be precisely those with the highest underlying childcare needs (e.g., more children, children with special needs, or parents with inflexible jobs). In this scenario, grandparents may indeed be providing substantial help, but it is not enough to lower the mother’s time burden to the level of a comparison household without such high needs. Our observable controls may not fully capture these differences, leading to a null finding that masks a true, but selective, effect.
2. **Heterogeneity of Grandparent Capacity:** The “grandparent” category is highly diverse. Some grandparents are young, healthy, and active, providing significant childcare. Others may be frail, in poor health, and require care themselves, adding to the household’s overall care burden. If these two effects are roughly balanced in the population, the average effect could be zero. Our finding that younger grandparents are

associated with *more* maternal childcare time hints at this complexity, possibly reflecting selection where younger grandparents co-reside with families having younger, more demanding children.

3. **Measurement Limitations of Time Diaries:** Standard time-use surveys may be too blunt to capture the true value of grandparent support. Grandparents may provide “passive” supervision or be “on call” as backup care, which frees up the mother’s mental energy and allows her to engage in other tasks more productively, but this may not be recorded as a reduction in her primary activity childcare minutes. Their contribution may lie in reducing stress and providing flexibility, not just logged time.
4. **Alternative Contributions:** Grandparents may contribute to the household in ways other than direct childcare, such as cooking, cleaning, or providing financial resources. These contributions benefit the family but would not be captured in an analysis focused solely on the mother’s childcare time.

4 Conclusion

This paper challenges a foundational assumption in the discourse on female labor and family in India: that co-resident grandparents provide a substantial childcare dividend. Using the nationally representative 2024 Time Use Survey, we find no statistically significant evidence to support this claim in urban India. Across a range of models, the presence of grandparents in the household has a near-zero, non-significant effect on the number of minutes a mother spends on childcare each day.

This null result is profoundly important. It suggests that the informal, family-based solutions often touted as a panacea for India’s low female labor force participation are not, on average, alleviating the time constraints that hold women back. While many individual grandparents are undoubtedly heroic caregivers, our aggregate analysis indicates that this is not a systemic

solution.